



**When things slow down and the machine's not too hot,
when applications take long to load and performance goes for a toss,
then you know it's time to put your PC through a STRESS TEST!**

There's nothing like the speed of a brand new PC. But over time, things start to change. Suddenly, applications don't load as quickly as before and simple tasks such as copying files take a lot longer. All in all, performance starts taking a nosedive.

A careless computer technician checks around and declares everything in working order while you keep insisting that the PC is slow. He recommends you to upgrade or purchase a new PC and throws some fancy figures at you. By this time, you're so brainwashed that you're actually letting yourself take his advice seriously.

Wait! This is one scenario that we hope you don't have to face—at least not after reading this. It's completely natural for a computer to lose its edge over a period of time, but that doesn't mean that it's gone forever.

In this article, we've uncovered some sure-fire ways of using conventional benchmarking software to ensure that your system is running to its fullest possible capability.

Each hardware category that we take you through is important in maintaining overall system performance. If one particular area isn't doing too well, it could have some negative effects on the speed of your PC.

THE CPU

Let's start with the head of the computing body, the central processing unit (CPU). The CPU is perhaps the single biggest factor impacting overall system performance. PCs are, in fact, sold more times on this one specification alone than all the other features combined together! It's this same reason that makes CPUs the choicest component to overclock and tweak.

SiSoft Sandra 2001 is amongst one of the most comprehensive benchmark applications currently available. The software specialises in individually testing and reporting the performance of various subsystems within a PC. To give your chip

summary of your PC's scores and that of other machines.

What to expect

SiSoft Sandra provides a specific frame of reference when benchmarking your PC. It only presents results of other machines with a configuration similar to yours, giving you a very good idea of where your system stands. Use can use the following figures to supplement your comparative efforts.

500 MHz CPU: 1350 ALU/670 FPU

1 GHz CPU: 2740 ALU/1363 FPU

1.5 GHz CPU: 3800 ALU/1940 FPU

Warning

Running any sort of CPU benchmark puts a lot of stress on the chip, since it utilises most

of its resources. If the CPU is faced with another task, its performance scores under SiSoft Sandra will suffer.

Close all running programs before running the test. Also, be sure to turn off all power management options in the BIOS so that the system does not slowdown while you benchmark.

System Prerequisites

486 or higher CPU, 12 MB of RAM, 10 MB of hard disk space



SiSoft Sandra's comparative analysis puts your PC in its place once you see the power-houses you're up against

a thorough shakedown, start up the SiSoft Sandra benchmark.

Locate the icon for CPU testing, double-click, and the test will immediately launch. Your test scores will arrive mere moments later—you'll see a comparative

THE MEMORY SUBSYSTEM

The performance of physical memory is a key component of overall PC speed. Being one of the slower components inside a PC, it tends to hold up other processes